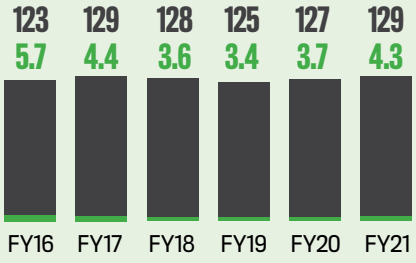
A SLOW BURN

AREA UNDER ORGANIC FARMING (million hectare)



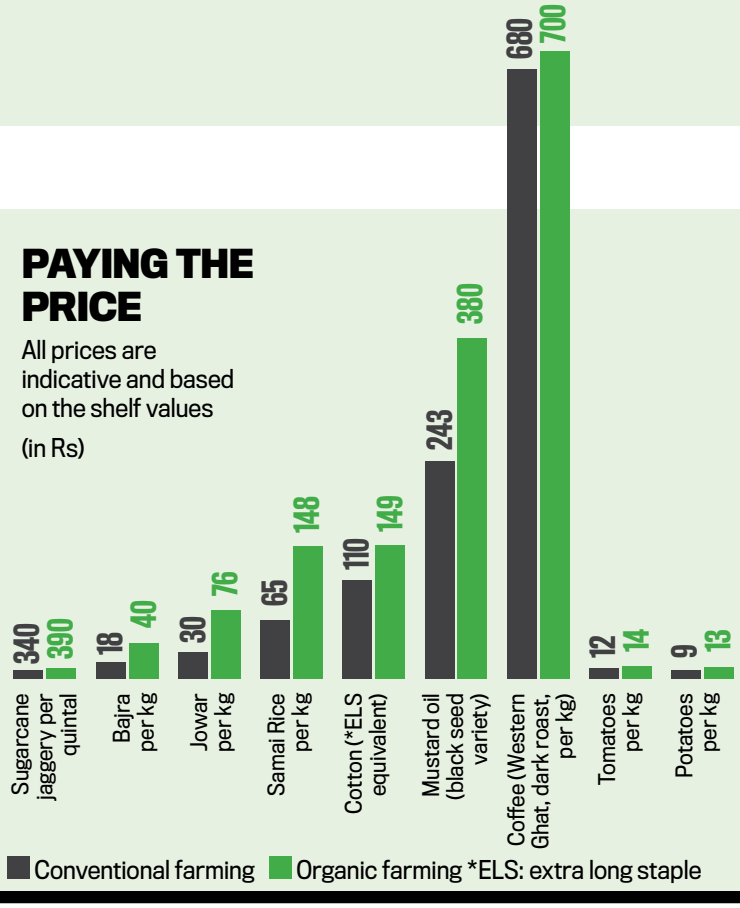
888,180 MT
Total export in 2020-21

3,496,800 MT
India's production in 2020-21

PAYING THE PRICE

All prices are indicative and based on the shelf values

(in Rs)



Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

Corporation of India and Cotton Corporation of India. Most of its farmers focus on growing crops that have this guaranteed procurement safety net. That's also an incentive to grow more, which is why they put all their effort into volumes. The result? A suffocating reliance on pesticides and fertilisers that naturally leaches into the soil, groundwater and, eventually, people's bloodstreams. In fact, fertiliser consumption has gone up substantially across India. Increasing from 12.4 kg per ha. in 1969, and growing at roughly 6 per cent every year, it has touched nearly 190 kg per ha. today. Punjab, Haryana, Bihar and Telangana have consistently consumed over 200 kg per ha. in the past decade.

NEED FOR AN ORGANIC MSP

At its core, the problem is basic: switching to organic farming is expensive. Ajay Kakra, practice leader, food and agriculture, PwC India, says farmers are hesitant to leave their land fallow for the mandated three years to ensure chemical residue is washed out before they switch to organic farming. "It is relatively easier for bigger farmers to leave some patch of their land fallow to gradually shift to organic farming," he adds. Most state governments look to the Centre for some mechanism to compensate farmers for this additional cost. Charanjit Channi, as Punjab's chief minister, had asked the Centre to consider offering assured MSP for organic produce. "Production falls when farmers switch to organic produce, so there has to be a new MSP mechanism for organic farmers," he said. His successor, Bhagwant Mann, is yet to offer his agriculture vision.

Certification is another vexed issue. Akash Badave, who runs the Bhoomgaadi Organic Farmer Producer Organisation in Chhattisgarh's Dantewada, says: "It's very difficult for tribals or smaller farmers to get a formal stamp certifying that their produce is organic." Badave works with 10,000-odd farmers who grow traditional varieties of paddy, millets, turmeric, pulses etc. and sell it to supermarkets in west and north India, under the brand name Aadim.

Another curious problem farmers face is that organic and natural produce, which they have to try and peg at a higher price, is often visually less appealing in shape and colour. "Local markets don't respond well to that," says Vijay Singh, an organic farmer from Sonepat. According to him, farmers can make money only if they circumvent the conventional supply chain and create a unique identity for their produce. In the past three years, several states have amended their respective Agriculture Produce Marketing Committee laws, allowing contract farming and marketing of produce directly to the consumers. In this respect, the recent repeal of the three farm laws has probably hit organic farmers the most: they would have opened up those avenues.

Since the full complement of organic farming is a daunting task and entails heavy input cost, an alternative that carries many of the benefits is under active consideration: natural farming. In its fundamentals, it overlaps with organic farming in adopting a zero-chemical approach, but comes with some distinctions (see *The Green Glossary*), especially in reducing the reliance on bulk organic manure. Some efforts have borne fruit in the past five years. States depend on central schemes to promote natural and organic farming—these include the ambitious Mission Organic Value Chain Development for Northeastern Region (MOVCDNER), the Paramparagat Kri-